

The Prison



INTRODUCTION

BRIEF BIOGRAPHY OF BERNARD MALAMUD

Bernard Malamud was a Jewish American author born in Brooklyn, New York. Malamud's parents fled tsarist Russia and immigrated to the United States before Malamud was born, but their experiences shaped his childhood and upbringing. Their family was poor and relied on a small grocery store his father owned as their primary income. When Malamud was 15, his mother died while in a mental institution, and Malamud took on responsibility for his older brother, Eugene, who struggled with the same mental illness as their mother. Though Malamud's father was barely literate in English, Malamud valued education and sought out opportunities to learn. He graduated from City College of New York and continued his education at Columbia University. In 1945, Malamud married Ann De Chiara, an Italian American Catholic woman, and together they had two children. He taught at various high schools in New York City, after which he taught at Oregon State University and Bennington College in Vermont. While living and teaching in Oregon, he prioritized making time to write, and during this time he published his first novel, *The Natural*, which would later become an emblem of his literary style. In addition to novels, Malamud also published several short story collections, one of which, *The Magic Barrel*, earned a National Book Award. Malamud received a second National Book Award and the Pulitzer Prize for Fiction for his fourth novel, *The Fixer*, in 1967. Much of his work, including *The Fixer*, explores the Jewish American immigrant experience and addresses antisemitism after the Holocaust. Before he died in 1986, Malamud published a total of eight novels and four collections of short stories.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

In the late 1800s and early 1900s, thousands of Jewish immigrants entered the United States to flee tsarist leadership, religious persecution, and antisemitism present throughout Eastern Europe, particularly Russia. Beginning in the 1880s, Soviet leaders implemented anti-Jewish pogroms, which led to over two million Jews fleeing the country between 1880 and 1920. Many Russian Jews fled to the United States, including Malamud's parents, and entered through Ellis Island. Few resources and discrimination in America limited them to settling in the Lower East Side of New York, where they lived in overcrowded, often dilapidated tenement homes. The Great Depression, though most detrimental to rural Americans, exacerbated poverty amidst immigrants and the resulting global economic crisis impacted both their jobs and quality of

life. As the Depression led into World War II, Jewish immigrants in particular endured countless tragedies and injustices. Many Jewish Americans fought in WWII, defending both their new home in America and their relatives facing the horrors of the Holocaust in Europe. Though Malamud was exempt from fighting in WWII as the sole provider for his family, he certainly encountered pro-Nazi movements in the United States, and his identity as a Jewish American, the legacy of his parents as Russian Jewish immigrants, and his upbringing in impoverished, tenement neighborhoods informed his writing about Americans of various backgrounds struggling with poverty and limited aspirations.

RELATED LITERARY WORKS

"The Prison" stands in the context of *The Magic Barrel*, Malamud's debut short story collection that centers on stories of similarly poor people in urban settings. The collection includes 12 more stories on these subjects, which, when read together, create a more comprehensive vision of Malamud's aim to highlight stories from impoverished, multi-ethnic urban communities. Though Malamud drew from his own experiences growing up in poverty and running a family store in the creation of "The Prison," Tommy's experiences are not overtly autobiographical. But Malamud's second novel, *The Assistant*, explores such ideas more directly. *The Assistant*, published in 1957, follows a Jewish immigrant who runs a small Brooklyn grocery store—much like Malamud's own father. Similarly, Malamud's novel *The Fixer*, published in 1966, tells a fictionalized account of Menahem Mendel Beilis, a Jew wrongfully imprisoned for murder in 1913 Tsarist Russia. Both novels offer glimpses of Malamud's identity as a child of Russian Jewish immigrants and as Jewish American. A generation younger than Malamud, Chaim Potok also explored the immigrant Russian Jewish experience and the spiritual and cultural lives of Jewish American communities in novels like *The Chosen* (1967) and *My Name is Asher Lev* (1972). More broadly, Malamud's realist focus on the lives of impoverished families and communities can be found in works such as James Joyce's 1914 short story collection *Dubliners* and John Steinbeck's *Of Mice and Men* (1937) and *The Grapes of Wrath* (1939).

KEY FACTS

- **Full Title:** The Prison
- **When Written:** 1950
- **Where Written:** Corvallis, Oregon
- **When Published:** 1950
- **Literary Period:** Contemporary

- **Genre:** Short Story, Social Realism
- **Setting:** The Village
- **Climax:** Rosa catches the girl stealing chocolate.
- **Antagonist:** The Girl
- **Point of View:** Third Person

EXTRA CREDIT

Publication History. “The Prison” was originally published in the September 1950 issue of *Commentary*, a magazine founded by the American Jewish Committee. The story later reappeared in *The Magic Barrel*, Malamud’s 1958 anthology of short stories, which won the National Book Award for Fiction in 1959.

A Lost Manuscript. In 1948, Malamud completed his first novel-length manuscript, titled *The Light Sleeper*. After several publishers rejected the work, Malamud burned the manuscript in his backyard. Today, there is no remaining evidence of the book’s contents.



PLOT SUMMARY

Tommy Castelli reflects on his life, from childhood to his present life as a 29-year-old man, and concludes that his life is boring. Before marrying Rosa, who changed his name to Tommy, he went by **Tony**, and he grew up in an overcrowded tenement building. He remembers dropping out of training to be a shoemaker to join a local gang, who prospered from their crimes. Though Tommy benefited from their spoils, the group disbanded when they held up a liquor store. Instead of suffering legal consequences, Tommy’s landlord made arrangements with the district’s gang leader to get him off the hook. Additionally, Tommy’s father arranged for Tommy to marry Rosa, whose father would buy a **candy store** for the couple to run together. Tommy initially pushed back on these decisions, fleeing to Texas, but he eventually returned and fulfilled their plans for him.

Now, in the present, Tommy works at the candy store nearly every day. When he is not working, he sleeps his time away. Even so, Tommy recalls a couple of times he did have the energy to pull off schemes like those of his childhood, such as illegally selling lottery cards and secretly installing a slot machine in the candy store. In both instances, though Tommy faced Rosa’s disapproval, he evaded legal punishment. Because of this, Tommy feels bad about both situations when he reflects on them. As he considers his life as a whole, he curses Rosa and the shop for controlling what he calls his “unhappy life.”

One day, while Tommy is working in the candy store, a ten-year-old girl enters the shop to buy tissue paper for her mother. Tommy recognizes the girl because she comes in every Monday

for the same items, so he instinctively goes to the back of the store to retrieve the paper. Rosa recently installed a mirror in the back of the store to keep an eye on the front counter, and as Tommy collects the paper, he watches the girl reach into a candy jar and steal two chocolate bars. His initial response is to punish her with physical violence, but he quickly remembers his Uncle Dom, who, before disappearing to jail, would spend intentional, quality time with Tommy. He remembers the grief he felt when Dom left, and he considers his own young life as a thief, which he connects to the girl in his store. Because of this, he decides not to say anything about the stolen candy. He notices the girl’s fear as she purchases the paper, which gives him pause. After she leaves, he feels he must speak to her about her thieving habit. But, because he despises the way others have attempted to reform his life, he struggles with *how* he should warn the girl. Tommy wants to do it right, and he plans to confront the girl the next Monday.

When the girl returns the following week, Tommy watches her steal again, but he finds that he cannot confront her. He blames himself for being “too chicken,” but ultimately convinces himself that he should attempt an indirect intervention that might lead her to stop of her own accord. He tries emptying certain candy jars and leaving out change for her to pay with, but she still steals the chocolate. Tommy decides to leave her a written note of warning in one of the chocolate wrappers, and he waits for her to return.

On the next Monday, he waits for the girl to grab the chocolate with the note, but she does not come. Tommy feels so disappointed and anxious that he gives himself a headache. While he is upstairs napping, Rosa catches the girl stealing. Tommy returns to the shop as Rosa shakes the girl, calling her a thief. Tommy slaps Rosa to stop her, but the girl’s mother enters the shop and threatens to burn the girl’s hands for her crime. As they leave, the girl sticks out her tongue at Tommy.



CHARACTERS

Tommy Castelli – Tommy, originally named **Tony**, is 29 years old, and he lives above **the candy store** he owns with his wife, Rosa. As a child, he grew up in a crowded tenement building, where he joined a gang of young men and began assisting in their crimes. When the group got caught holding up a liquor store, Tommy’s landlord kept him from facing legal consequences, but Tommy looks back on the situation with disdain. Similarly, he resents his father for arranging a marriage between him and Rosa, and he resents Rosa’s father for buying them the candy store. He finds his life unfulfilling, which leads him to sleep away most of the time when he is not working. When Tommy notices the girl stealing for the first time, it causes him to reflect on the potential impact he could have on her life. Though Tommy despises the individuals who have controlled the trajectory of his life, the girl’s recurrent stealing

forces him to consider his own potential influence. The regret he feels for his past actions and the empathy he feels for the girl create a sense of cognitive dissonance within Tommy. He wants to help, but he doesn't want to overstep, and this internal struggle ultimately causes him to lose the opportunity to reform the girl.

The Girl – The girl is 10 years old, and Tommy describes her physical appearance as plain but sharp; she has pale skin contrasted by very dark eyes. She is a weekly customer of Tommy and Rosa Castelli, and she purchases colored tissue paper for her mother every Monday. However, each time she makes this purchase, she also steals two chocolate bars from the **store**. Each time Tommy attempts to subtly correct this habit, she either ignores his warnings or does not notice them, continuing to steal the chocolate. Before he realizes she is stealing, Tommy assumes that the girl hangs back by the candy jars out of fear; later, he also assumes she will be fearful of him if he were to call out her stealing directly. However, the only time the girl appears afraid is when Rosa catches her stealing, making her face look “sickly.” This fear seems short-lived, as the girl sticks her tongue out at Tommy as her mother drags her out of the store. Her sassy response to Tommy’s presence reveals her likely indifference toward any reform he might have given her. Due to her mother’s apparent abuse, the girl likely distrusts adults in her life and feels skepticism toward Tommy’s attempts at empathy.

Rosa Castelli – Rosa is Tommy’s wife, and she helps run their **candy store**. Rosa’s father bought and opened the candy store for the couple to earn money honestly for their life together. Tommy describes Rosa as “too plain and lank,” but he marries her anyway. Rosa is strict in the way she runs the store, and she dislikes when Tommy is lazy or attempts illegal schemes. She responds violently to discovering the girl stealing chocolate. Her harsh, rule-following personality contrasts with Tommy’s disinterested, passive habits.

Uncle Dom – Dom is Tommy’s uncle, and while he is no longer present in Tommy’s life, he often pops up in Tommy’s memories and self-reflections. At some point in Tommy’s childhood, Dom went to jail; when his sentence ended, he disappeared. Before Uncle Dom disappeared, however, he used to take Tommy crabbing, just the two of them. Tommy remembers these moments fondly, but Dom’s absence still brings him sadness. Now that many years have passed, Tommy worries that he may not recognize Dom should they ever meet again.

The Girl’s Mother – The girl’s mother runs an after-school care and needs tissue paper each week for the children to make dolls. Though the girl always runs this errand for her, when the mother picks her up from the **store** in the final scene, she reacts violently and harshly to the girl’s thievery.



THEMES

In LitCharts literature guides, each theme gets its own color-coded icon. These icons make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. If you don't have a color printer, you can still use the icons to track themes in black and white.



GUILT AND REGRET

From the beginning of “The Prison,” Tommy describes his life as continually facing “this sick-in-the-stomach feeling of being trapped in old mistakes.” As Tommy reflects on his life up to the present, he alludes to his childhood involved in petty crime. Having grown up in an overcrowded tenement, he dreamed of getting out of his impoverished neighborhood; at the time, the gang of young men who committed crimes but had money enticed him, so he joined their group. Tommy’s decision to join the group, and his subsequent decisions to participate in their crimes, up until robbing a liquor store, haunt him over a decade later (the story’s present). Additionally, he experiences regret for his more recent choices, such as illegally selling lottery cards and having a slot machine in the **candy store** he owns. Though in each instance Tommy escapes punishment, he feels his life with Rosa and the candy store, as well as the guilt of knowing he might have been given a harsher punishment, is an enduring consequence. His regret leads him into a depression, which manifests in his constant desire to sleep his life away.

When Tommy notices the girl stealing chocolate for the first time, the regret that burdens him every day compels him to correct her actions. At the same time that his regret pushes him to reform the girl, however, his guilt cripples his corrective actions. Guilt keeps him from speaking to the girl the first time he catches her stealing; he worries his reform could hurt her based on the fear already in her eyes. He does not want to exert control over the girl’s life, as has been his own experience with reform. As a result, Tommy views his failure to correct the girl as an indicator of his own inadequacy, which adds another layer to his preexisting guilt. When he considers the trail of decisions he has made and how they have resulted in his present situation, the burden of his past mistakes continues to wear him down, and he loses the opportunity to confront the girl. Through Tommy’s inability to correct the girl, “The Prison” reveals the unique challenges that face those suffering under the burden of past mistakes, suggesting that unresolved guilt and regret can inhibit a person from moving on and helping others of similar background.



EMPATHY

Because of his own youthful crimes, Tommy feels a connection to the girl he catches stealing chocolate

from his candy store. Rather than react in anger, he compares himself as a young boy to the girl. In addition to his past mistakes, he remembers his Uncle Dom, who intentionally took care of Tommy yet disappeared to prison while Tommy was still young. Tommy finds himself “thinking about the way his life had turned out, and then about this girl, moved that she was so young and a thief.” In other words, Tommy experiences a sense of empathy for the girl, which motivates him to take action in hopes of reforming her habits. Rather than letting her ruin her life as he feels he has ruined his own, he wants to do something for her in the same way his Uncle Dom and others took care of him at a young age.

Even so, Tommy does not forget the ways the would-be reformers in his own life put him in his current situation—enduring a monotonous life he despises. Tommy deliberates between punishing the girl for her crime or warning her what could happen if she continues. According to Tommy, “the role of reformer was strange and distasteful...yet he could not convince himself that what he felt he must do was unimportant.” Because of this contradiction, in the same way his empathy pushes him to correct the girl, it also forces him to consider the *best* way to correct her. He worries that if he is too aggressive, she may not take him seriously and call him a “jerk;” at the same time, he does not want to scare her by being too direct. Though he never successfully goes through with any of his plans to confront the girl, his familiarity with her position—as both a former offender and the object of reform—makes him empathetic in a way that others (like Rosa, who yells at her, and her mother, who threatens her with punishment) completely fail to be. The empathy Tommy feels represents an alternative to the negative reform he experienced—though, ironically, it arguably stops him from acting when he should, suggesting that those in a position to feel empathy are seldom in the best position to act on it.



POWERLESSNESS

The root of Tommy’s distaste for his life in “The Prison” lies in his constant state of powerlessness. His feeling of powerlessness traces back to his

childhood in his “tenement-crowded, kid-squawking neighborhood, with its lousy poverty.” He recalls being a child with many dreams, but the environment he grew up in quickly made those dreams impossible due to a lack of resources. He had the opportunity to be a shoemaker, but after he quit his training to join the gang of young men in his district, the short-lived prosperity he experienced while working with them gave way to a lifestyle completely controlled by others. Tommy’s landlord steps in to prevent legal consequences for his crimes with the gang, and his father arranges a marriage between Tommy and Rosa, whose father establishes a **candy store** for them to run. Yet, when he escapes to Texas to avoid their arrangements for his life, he is powerless to stay away,

returning to fulfill their plan for a wedding and job. From his impoverished childhood to his adult marriage and career, Tommy is powerless to direct his own life.

This powerlessness continues when Tommy wants to correct the girl stealing chocolate from his store. Finally, he has the power to step into someone’s life to hopefully change it for the better, in the same way others have made decisions for him. However, his goal is not to control the girl’s life; instead, he aims to warn her of where it may go. Even so, Tommy’s life of powerlessness impedes his ability to warn the girl about the potential consequences of her thievery, and he can never get the words out or complete his plans to correct her. He does not know how to apply his theoretical power to redirect her habits because having any power is completely foreign to him; so, he fails to do anything to change the girl’s life. In turn, the girl faces a more violent consequence for her stealing than the words of warning Tommy planned to give her. Tommy’s powerlessness ultimately pushes him to claim that life itself is a prison, as his loss of agency has led to a lifestyle of familial and societal control. “The Prison,” in turn, suggests that layers of socioeconomic forces create a repeating cycle of powerlessness in people like Tommy, teaching them to be helpless even when presented with the opportunity to change.



SYMBOLS

Symbols appear in **teal text** throughout the Summary and Analysis sections of this LitChart.



TONY

Tommy’s birth name, Tony, symbolizes his past self. As Tony, Tommy aspired to a life beyond his impoverished neighborhood. Yet, under the name Tony, he also dropped out of an apprenticeship to join a gang and aid in their illegal activities. According to Tommy’s self-reflection, “He had been as Tony a kid of many dreams and schemes, especially getting out of this tenement-crowded, kid-squawking neighborhood, with its lousy poverty, but everything had fouled up against him before he could.” When he finally succumbs to the plans his father and Rosa’s father have made for them, including marriage and running the candy store, Rosa changes Tony into Tommy. Not only does she change his name, but she reshapes his personality and lifestyle. He no longer holds great aspirations, instead trudging through each monotonous day in the shop in boredom. He follows her rules for running the shop, and even when he reverts to his past habits, such as illegally selling lottery cards or installing a slot machine, he always goes back to the upstanding persona Rosa has created for him to embody.

When Tommy reflects on his memories with Uncle Dom, he refers to himself as Tony, rather than Tommy. This subtle

change creates distance between who he is now, in the present, and who he was then, when he could meet with Uncle Dom face-to-face. Though he does not share what happened to Uncle Dom or where he went, Tommy shares how meaningful it was that Dom would spend intentional time with Tony. Dom showed him kindness but also caused him deep grief in his absence. After Tommy reveals that Dom spent time in jail, the memory also represents the trajectory Tony's life may have taken without the intervention of the people who changed him into Tommy. Tony may symbolize a life of aspiration, but the name also represents a life as an impoverished person, forced into criminal behavior in order to have a hope of prospering.



THE CANDY STORE

Tommy and Rosa's candy store represents Tommy's feeling of being trapped. Throughout "The Prison," Tommy frequently highlights the idea that he is not in control of his own life. After he evades legal consequences for holding up a liquor store with the gang, after his father arranges his marriage to Rosa, and after Rosa's father buys the store for them to run, Tommy feels as if there is no room for him to make his own decisions. Instead, he is trapped within the confines of the world created for him by his marriage and career. Furthermore, Rosa's expectations for when and how Tommy should work in the store control him daily. After Tommy fails to intercede in the girl's stealing habit, he once again reflects on his life. He concludes, "No matter how hard you tried you made mistakes and couldn't get past them. You could never see the sky outside or the ocean because you were in a prison, except nobody called it a prison." His decisions resulted in outside individuals making decisions for him, like the candy store, and those decisions actively impact his access to a fresh start.

Related Themes:



Related Symbols:



Page Number: 149

Explanation and Analysis

This passage provides insight into Tommy's attitude toward his life and his lack of control over events in his life. Tommy's daily life is monotonous and repetitive, which results in feelings of apathy and boredom. But, while he dislikes this lifestyle, the shadow of his past mistakes impacts him far more. As he describes, he feels physically sick at the thought of his past, yet he cannot escape its control over his life. Despite having a new name—Rosa started calling him "Tommy" instead of the childhood "Tony"—the mistakes he made in his previous identity continue to follow him each day. The passage also exposes the fact that Tommy did not choose to shift identities; instead, Rosa assigned this new name to him. This lack of choice not only highlights Tommy's lack of power in his life, but more importantly, the lack of control he has over his identity. Together, his mundane lifestyle and the burden of his mistakes create a life Tommy finds draining and depressing.

☞ Lucky for him the coal-and-ice man who was their landlord knew the leader in the district, and they arranged something so nobody bothered him after that. Then before he knew what was going on—he had been frightened sick by the whole mess—there was his father cooking up a deal with Rosa Agnello's old man that Tony would marry her and the father-in-law would, out of his savings, open a candy store for him to make an honest living.

Related Characters: Tommy Castelli, Rosa Castelli

Related Themes:



Related Symbols:



Page Number: 149

Explanation and Analysis

This passage provides direct examples of Tommy's powerlessness in his life. Though he avoids legal punishment for his actions with the gang, any relief he might feel is tempered by the lack of control he has over the situation that follows. His landlord steps in to prevent



QUOTES

Note: all page numbers for the quotes below refer to the Cambridge University Press edition of *Stories of Ourselves: Volume 1* published in 2018.

The Prison Quotes

☞ Though he tried not to think of it, at twenty-nine Tommy Castelli's life was a screaming bore. It wasn't just Rosa or the store they tended for profits counted in pennies, or the unendurably slow hours and endless drivel that went with selling candy, cigarettes, and soda water; it was this sick-in-the-stomach feeling of being trapped in old mistakes, even some he had made before Rosa changed Tony into Tommy.

Related Characters: Tommy Castelli, Rosa Castelli

consequences, his father steps in to arrange a marriage, and his father-in-law steps in to set up a steady job for him. In each situation, Tommy does not have the ability to choose his fate, whether it be jailtime, romance, or a career. Because of his history of crime, the people in his life distrust his ability to act on his own, and together they intervene in creating a life for him. While their actions have certainly helped Tommy avoid prison and poverty, they have also stripped him of any power or independence over the trajectory of his life—prompting readers to question whether these decisions, however well-meaning, have ultimately served Tommy's best interest.

☛ The next day the cops raided for slot machines and gave out summonses wherever they found them, and though Tommy's place was practically the only candy store in the neighborhood that didn't have one, he felt bad about the machine for a long time.

Related Characters: Tommy Castelli

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 150

Explanation and Analysis

This sentence comes at the end of Tommy's recollection of the slot machine he secretly installed in the candy store. Conveniently, Rosa discovered the machine and her father destroyed it the day before police raided neighborhood stores for the illegal machines, but Tommy still experiences guilt for the crime he committed and the punishment he avoided. Yet again, this event is an instance of Tommy avoiding consequences not through his own choices, but through the decisions made and actions imposed by other people in his life—making it another example of the powerlessness Tommy experiences repeatedly in the story. The guilt he feels from this occurrence grows into a feeling of regret that compounds with the regret he already carries for the crimes of his childhood. Together, they form a burden that impacts him every day as the people around him and his tasks in the candy store remind him of his past life and the attempts of others to change it.

☛ Time rotted in him, and all he could think of the whole morning, was going to sleep in the afternoon, and he would wake up with the sour remembrance of the long night in the store ahead of him, while everybody else was doing as he damn pleased. He cursed the candy store and Rosa, and cursed, from its beginning, his unhappy life.

Related Characters: Tommy Castelli, Rosa Castelli

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 150

Explanation and Analysis

This passage highlights Tommy's disdain for his current lifestyle as well as the depression caused by his powerlessness within it. Rather than enjoy each day and live his life to the fullest, Tommy wishes his life would pass more quickly, and, for the most part, he sleeps his days away. He dreads each aspect of his routine, from waking up to hours spent in the store, because he has no choice in it, and he envies the freedom he sees in the lives of others. Tommy's powerlessness, which starkly contrasts with the power he observes others experiencing, leads him to curse his life, as well as the primary forces within it. Notably, however, he curses his *entire* life, including the times before he lost the power of choice. In doing so, he curses his low-income upbringing and the impoverished setting of his childhood, which led him to join the gang in the first place.

☛ He felt at first like grabbing her by the neck and socking till she threw up, but he had been caught, as he sometimes was, by this thought of how his Uncle Dom, years ago before he went away, used to take with him Tony alone of all the kids, when he went crabbing to Sheepshead Bay.

Related Characters: Tommy Castelli, The Girl, Uncle Dom

Related Themes: 

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 150-151

Explanation and Analysis

In this sentence, Tommy exhibits a hard shift from violence to empathy. His initial response to learning that the girl is

stealing from him is physical violence, but before he can act on it, his thoughts redirect to the memory of his Uncle Dom. Though the story does not reveal very much information about Uncle Dom, the innocent memory that Tommy meditates on demonstrates Dom's intentionality in taking care of Tony. As the memory briefly unfolds, Tommy hints at Dom's significance in his childhood as well as his later disappearance. The story later reveals that Dom went to jail, leaving Tommy without a mentor. While the memory itself seems negligible, it has a big impact on Tommy's life and the present moment with the girl. The memory forces him to pause and reconsider his immediate response to the girl's stealing. This quote is also significant because it not only demonstrates that Tommy is capable of empathy, but that he might be capable of influencing others' lives for the better the way his Uncle Dom did, or at least trying to.

☞ He found himself thinking about the way his life had turned out, and then about this girl, moved that she was so young and a thief. He felt he ought to do something for her, warn her to cut it out before she got trapped and fouled up her life before it got started. His urge to do this was strong, but when he went forward she looked up frightened because he had taken so long. The fear in her eyes bothered him and he didn't say anything.

Related Characters: Tommy Castelli, The Girl

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 151

Explanation and Analysis

This passage comes after Tommy watches the girl steal for the first time, as he contemplates how he should respond to her crime. Though his immediate thought is to choose physical violence, his sense of empathy kicks in as he considers alternative approaches to correcting the girl. Her youthfulness reminds him of himself as a child committing petty crimes. As an adult, Tommy lives with regret for these past mistakes every day, and he hopes that he can prevent the girl from living under a similar burden someday. However, though he wants to intervene in her thieving habit, he finds that he is powerless to do so. He blames the girl's fear for preventing him from warning her against future stealing, and his empathy informs the decision to pause, but he also allows his powerlessness to get the best of him. Where he could have stopped a problem at the outset, his constant sense of powerlessness cripples him

each time he has the opportunity to act.

☞ He kept trying to make the desire to speak to her go away, but it came back stronger than ever. He asked himself what difference does it make if she swipes candy—so she swipes it; and the role of the reformer was strange and distasteful to him, yet he could not convince himself that what he felt he must do was unimportant.

Related Characters: Tommy Castelli, The Girl

Related Themes: 

Page Number: 151

Explanation and Analysis

In this passage, Tommy experiences an inner struggle regarding how he should respond to the girl's thievery. Because the girl comes in every week at the same time, he knows that he will have another opportunity to warn her about her habit, and while he attempts to forget about it, the thought haunts him. In the same way that his regret for his own crimes preoccupies his thoughts every day, the memory of the girl begins to linger in his mind. The role of the reformer is very real to Tommy, as his everyday life is impacted by the decisions would-be reformers once made for him. The thought of impacting the girl in a similar, negative way worries him, yet he cannot shake the feeling that correcting her habit could prevent her from enduring a powerless life similar to his own. This knowledge leads him to strategize his intervention more carefully, because he knows firsthand the potential damage he could have on the girl's life.

☞ Afterwards, he told himself that he hadn't spoken to her because it was while she still had the candy on her, and she would have been scared worse than he wanted. When he went upstairs, instead of sleeping, he sat at the kitchen window, looking out into the back yard. He blamed himself for being too soft, too chicken, but then he thought, no there was a better way to do it. He would do it indirectly, slip her a hint he knew, and he was pretty sure that would stop her. Sometime after, he would explain her why it was a good idea she had stopped.

Related Characters: Tommy Castelli, The Girl

Related Themes:   

Page Number: 151

Explanation and Analysis

This passage highlights the care Tommy puts into planning his warning for the girl while also exposing his continued powerlessness in the situation. Tommy begins to experience regret for his inability to confront the girl in addition to his daily regret for his past mistakes. As his burden grows, so do his feelings of powerlessness, as he cannot seem to successfully correct her. Despite these growing hindrances, Tommy maintains a sense of empathy as he plans his intervention. He concludes that a more indirect approach will be best, and because this attempt at reform is so important to him, he wants it done in a way that will be successful. Because the reformers in his life stripped him of his autonomy, he wants the girl to come to her own conclusion that she should not steal in order for her to maintain a sense of control over her life. Additionally, this passage shows how the desire to correct the girl has given him a sense of purpose. Rather than sleep his time away, as he has a habit of doing, he now strategizes his intervention during his breaks from the store.

☞ He thought about Dom getting out of jail and going away God knows where. He wondered whether he would ever meet up with him somewhere, if he took the fifty-five bucks and left. Then he remembered Dom was a pretty old guy now, and he might not know him if they did meet. He thought about life. You never really got what you wanted. No matter how hard you tried you made mistakes and couldn't get past them. You could never see the sky outside or the ocean because you were in a prison, except nobody called it a prison, and if you did they didn't know what you were talking about, or they said they didn't. A pall settled on him. He lay motionless, without thought or sympathy for himself or anybody.

Related Characters: Tommy Castelli, Uncle Dom

Related Themes:  

Related Symbols: 

Page Number: 152

Explanation and Analysis

Tommy's reflections in this passage come after the girl fails to visit the candy store at her regular time. Tommy, having planted a direct note of warning with the chocolate bars, feels defeated—because she did not show up, he feels he

has failed her and lost his opportunity to reform her. He once again remembers Uncle Dom, this time experiencing powerlessness in his ability to reunite with his mentor. He falls into a pessimistic sequence of thoughts, concluding that mistakes are permanent. And, in his experience, they *have been*: his decisions as a young person have directly shaped the life he now lives.

Tommy introduces the story's guiding metaphor when he argues that life is a prison. While he may not live in a prison cell, he similarly cannot escape the candy store, his role as a husband, etc. He is powerless to go find his Uncle Dom, and he is powerless to confront the girl. Most importantly, Tommy feels trapped by the burden of his past mistakes. No matter how much time passes or how hard he tries to correct the same habits in others, he remains imprisoned. This bleak conclusion highlights the continued cycle of powerlessness in his life, which began in his impoverished childhood and continues in his guilt-ridden adulthood.

☞ The girl, like a grotesque dancer, half ran, half fell forward, but at the door she managed to turn her white face and thrust out at him her red tongue.

Related Characters: Tommy Castelli, The Girl

Related Themes:  

Page Number: 153

Explanation and Analysis

In this sentence, the girl mocks Tommy by sticking out her tongue as she leaves the store, solidifying his failure to make a positive impact on her. At the same time, the girl's stubbornness in the face of violent punishment from her mother suggests that Tommy's efforts, despite the empathy he hoped to employ, would likely have been unsuccessful.

Notably, Malamud creates an image of the girl with contrasting colors—white and red. White often symbolizes purity and innocence, which contradicts the girl's identity as a habitual thief. The girl is clearly guilty of a crime, yet she maintains an appearance of innocence. This color may reveal that the girl does not feel guilty about her actions, which is striking compared to Tommy's constant guilt and regret for his own crimes. Red, on the other hand, often symbolizes passion and anger. Adding these emotions to the sassiness and stubbornness of the girl's final action, Malamud reveals the girl's disdain for Tommy despite his effort to defend her. Just as Tommy was initially worried that the girl would respond in anger to his reform, she has

indeed responded in passion and anger to his failed attempt

at intervention in her life.



SUMMARY AND ANALYSIS

The color-coded icons under each analysis entry make it easy to track where the themes occur most prominently throughout the work. Each icon corresponds to one of the themes explained in the Themes section of this LitChart.

THE PRISON

Tommy Castellini reflects on his life as a 29-year-old man. He considers his career as a **candy store** owner, his marriage to Rosa, and alludes to past mistakes, ultimately drawing the conclusion that his life is boring. He recalls his childhood, when he went by **Tony** and was full of “schemes and dreams.” At 16, he dropped out of training to be a shoemaker and began to hang out with a violent gang of young men. Tommy identifies this decision as the beginning of his troubles. After robbing a liquor store with the gang, rather than getting arrested, Tommy’s landlord set a plan in motion that protected Tommy. But this protection led to an arranged marriage to Rosa. Tommy ran away to Texas in hopes of avoiding the wedding, but he eventually returned and began the life he has now: husband to Rosa and owner of the candy store.

Considering the present moment, Tommy works nearly every day at **the candy store**. When he’s not working, he either sleeps or goes to see a movie alone. Tommy is “too tired” to attempt the schemes of his youth, but he remembers a time when he made some extra money by secretly selling lottery cards. He kept this secret and his earnings from Rosa, but the local newspaper exposed the system and ended his hustle. He also remembers the time he installed a slot machine at the store when Rosa was away, but when she returned she screamed at the sight of it. Her father destroyed the machine with a hammer in anger. Coincidentally, Rosa and her father saved him from the police raid targeting gambling the next day, though Tommy still feels guilty for not enduring the same punishments as others. Caught in the daily routine of the candy store, Tommy curses the store, Rosa, and his “unhappy life.”

One morning, a 10-year-old girl enters **the candy store** to buy two rolls of tissue paper for her mother, who provides care for children after school. The girl begins to buy the tissue paper every Monday, and Tommy forms the habit of getting the paper from the back of the store for her each week. When he retrieves the paper, he notices the girl stays at the counter, as if she is afraid to go into the darker area of the store, despite the fact that he keeps the comics there as well. When he hands the girl the paper, she habitually gives him the dimes she owes and leaves quickly.

Tommy’s memories highlight the powerlessness he felt as a child and continues to feel as an adult. Though brief, his descriptions of his childhood neighborhood reveal his family’s poverty and the economic hardship he has overcome since. The repercussions for his involvement in his neighborhood’s gang similarly expose his lack of control over his life—both his wife and career were chosen for him. Though he tried to reclaim some power by fleeing to Texas, the attempt failed—readers aren’t told why—and he succumbed again to the control of others. Readers can infer that after having so many parts of life decided for him, Tommy struggled to take the initiative to start fresh in Texas without help. Additionally, Tommy’s reflections illuminate the extent to which regret for his actions as a young person burden his present. Where he used to have dreams and aspirations, his regret and powerlessness have led to him becoming indifferent to life.



Tommy consistently avoids punishment for his actions, but this does not spare him from the feeling of guilt. Though he acknowledges his luck in ending both his schemes right before police became involved, he knows that he should have suffered consequences. His lack of punishment only makes him feel guiltier, because he witnesses other storeowners suffering the consequences he knows he deserves. His daily routine at the candy store further reveals his powerlessness, as his dislike for Rosa and the store acts as a daily reminder of how little control he has over his life. When he curses his life, he demonstrates the extent to which he despises his lack of control—and how angry words are nearly the only resource he has left.



Tommy’s attention to the girl’s body language and his assumption that she is afraid reveal his empathy. Despite his obvious dislike of the store, he is still attentive to the customers he routinely encounters. He anticipates the girl’s needs and her presumed fear, willingly retrieving the paper for her so that she does not have to go into the dark space. These details set up Tommy’s development as a character—there’s more to him than bitterness and regret—and prompt readers to wonder what further role the girl will play.



Because Rosa is suspicious of customers, she hangs a mirror in the back of **the candy store** so she and Tommy can see the front of the store when they retrieve products. When the girl comes in for the first time since the mirror's installation, Tommy notices her movements in the mirror. He watches her reach into the candy case and grab two chocolate bars. His immediate reaction is anger, but then he remembers his Uncle Dom, who would take **Tony** crabbing. A joyful memory of catching a large, green lobster with Dom leads him to remember his grief at Dom's absence. Tommy then considers how his own life has unfolded, and he is moved by the girl's habit of thieving at such a young age. He plans to warn her not to steal again, but when he sees the fear in her eyes, he cannot follow through.

After the girl leaves, Tommy's desire to warn her to stop thieving grows stronger and stronger. He tries to shake it, because he resents the reform other people have imposed on his own life, but he cannot successfully convince himself not to reform the girl. He feels it is too important not to do, but he wants it to be done rightly, so he begins practicing how he can correct her. He doesn't want to seem too much like a jerk, but he also doesn't want to scare her. Tommy keeps the knowledge of her stealing a secret, but thinks of it often before she returns on the next Monday.

The next Monday, Tommy feels so anxious about confronting the girl that he has already smoked a whole pack of cigarettes before opening **the candy store**. He knows what he wants to say, but he now fears she may not come in. When she does enter the store, he retrieves the tissue paper as usual, worried she may not steal this time and he will miss the chance to say anything. When he watches her steal two chocolate bars again in the mirror, he finds he cannot move to catch her or correct her. He cannot remember what he planned to say, and he takes her payment for the tissue paper without a word.

After the girl leaves, Tommy reflects on his inability to confront her. When he is done at **the candy store**, instead of sleeping like usual, Tommy gazes out into the backyard and blames himself for being "too soft" to stand up to the girl. But he decides there may be a better way to confront her. He makes new plans to reform her habit indirectly. Then, once she stops stealing, he will discuss the habit with her directly. First, he empties the jar she typically steals from. But the girl only briefly hesitates before stealing from the next jar. The next week, he empties the whole shelf of jars, but the girl just steals from the shelf below. On the next Monday, he puts some spare change out in a dish, thinking she will use it to pay for the chocolate, but she still steals it.

Tommy's immediate anger upon catching the girl stealing represents the expected response to stealing, but his quick shift to remembering his own childhood again reveals his empathy. Though his recollection of Uncle Dom is brief, it points to the impact one person can have on another's life through their intentional effort and care. Rather than dwell on his anger, he allows the girl's similarity to himself as a young person to temper his anger. Comparing his own childhood to the girl's, his empathy then pushes him to intervene in her habit. At the same time, his inability to take action demonstrates his powerlessness, as he does not know what to do with his newfound potential to impact someone else's life—it's a new, unfamiliar experience for him.



Tommy's regret expands from his past actions to include his lost opportunity to correct the girl. In this instance, however, his regret motivates him to act differently the next time the girl comes into the store. Similarly, the powerlessness he experiences in his own life motivates him to intervene in the girl's life in a way that maintains her autonomy but corrects her habit. In other words, he doesn't want to force anything on the girl in a way that ultimately does more harm than good. Together, these motivating forces fuel his empathy as he strategizes how he can effectively reform the girl.



When Tommy once again fails to confront the girl, his powerlessness persists, and his regret deepens. Tommy's anxiety surrounding the situation highlights his inability to act on the power he suddenly has to redirect the girl's life. He has no experience with power and he is insecure in his ability to wield it well, to the point that he loses his opportunity.



Because Tommy finds it difficult to exert his power directly over the girl, he determines that indirect methods will be more successful. Additionally, his empathy leads him to believe these indirect methods will maximize his positive impact on the girl. Considering her feelings, he suspects that she is more likely to take his correction if she comes to the decision to stop stealing on her own, rather than him scaring her off with direct confrontation. However, Tommy's continued failure to reform the girl only deepens his frustration and anxiety.



Rosa begins to notice that Tommy is caught up thinking about something, but he does not tell her about the girl, even when she asks why he is eating so much chocolate. Rosa grows suspicious that he may be involved with another woman, but Tommy does not care as long as she does not discern the real issue on his mind. Tommy determines he must be more explicit in his attempts to correct the girl, so he decides to leave two chocolate bars on a plate. He also plans to write a note of warning to the girl and slip it under the wrapper of one of the bars. He writes, "Don't do this any more or you will suffer your whole life," and signs it, "Your Friend."

By Monday, a few days after crafting his plan, Tommy is impatient for the girl to arrive. However, she does not appear. After waiting a long time for her arrival, Rosa begins working in **the candy store**, and Tommy leaves disappointed. He still cannot sleep and can only think about the girl until he develops a headache. His mind wanders again to Uncle Dom, and he recalls Dom getting out of jail only to disappear again. He wonders if he will meet Dom again and grows sad at the fact that he might not recognize Dom if they ever did meet, because so much time has passed. He then reflects on life in general and asserts that you never get what you want, and that mistakes are inevitable. Because of these ideas, he compares life to a prison that doesn't let you move past your mistakes. The thought makes him apathetic toward life as he lays in bed to pass the time.

When Tommy returns to **the candy store**, surprised that Rosa hasn't called him in sooner, he finds the store is full and Rosa is yelling. As he shoves through the crowd, he sees that Rosa has caught the girl stealing the chocolates. Rosa is shaking the girl and yelling at her, and Tommy rips Rosa away from the now frightened girl. He asks Rosa what the matter is, and when Rosa replies that the girl is a thief, Tommy tells her to be quiet and slaps her across the face. Tommy slaps her harder than he means to, and it sends her to the floor where she remains quiet, looking around in a daze.

Rosa's lack of trust in Tommy exposes the control she still holds over his daily life. She justifies this distrust with his past mistakes, and her power over him conversely fuels his feelings of powerlessness. Furthermore, Tommy's failure to reform the girl with indirect methods leads him to his most direct strategy yet—leaving her a note. Though the note has a warning tone, the signature "Your Friend" demonstrates his desire to reach her with intentionality and empathy.



Tommy's guilt and regret both in his past mistakes and in his inability to confront the girl prompt his self-reflection. His memories of Uncle Dom, which previously led him to respond with empathy, now lead him to the cruel conclusion that life is a prison. Similarly, his determination that mistakes are final, debilitating forces in a person's life furthers his feelings of powerlessness. In this way, the burden of guilt and regret that once motivated his attempts at reforming the girl shift to amplify the powerlessness ever-present in his life. Together, these forces solidify Tommy's metaphorical prison, trapping him in his feelings of apathy, boredom, and disappointment.



Rosa's discovery of the girl's thievery leads to the very result Tommy hoped to prevent, that the girl would respond to correction in fear and consequently resent it. Tommy's violent response to Rosa's cruelty likely goes beyond the situation with the girl, acting as a culminating response to years of his passivity under her control of his life. And, ironically, despite his efforts to refrain from a violent reaction to the girl's thievery, he ends up acting violently anyway.



Tommy orders the girl to go home, but her mother enters **the candy store** before she can move. When the mother asks what happened, Rosa tells her that her daughter stole candy, while Tommy says he gave the candy to the girl. Tommy's statement shocks Rosa, and she begins to sob. The girl tells her mom that one chocolate bar was for her, but her mother slaps her and calls her a thief. She threatens that she will burn the girl's hands, yanking her out of the candy store. As the mother pulls the girl out of the store, the girl turns and sticks her tongue out at Tommy.

The violent response of the girl's mother contrasts with Tommy's attempt at empathy, but his ultimate failure to confront the girl leads to an ironic ending, where the girl will likely face a harsher punishment than Tommy initially intended. Furthermore, though Tommy was finally given an opportunity to use the same power others hold over him to benefit another person, he fails, continuing the repeating cycle of powerlessness in his life. The girl's sassy response adds a comedic tone to the otherwise cruel ending, suggesting the girl will likely continue in her illegal habit regardless of punishment. Finally, readers can infer that her sassiness also sharpens the pain of Tommy's regret, highlighting his failure to influence her life and adding to the burden of guilt he carries.





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